

Bracing for long fight, recovery

High winds expected to return as fire investigators look back and officials look forward



A POLICE officer patrols an area of Altadena burned by the Eaton fire. Investigators are looking at an electrical transmission tower as the possible origin of the blaze. GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

Assessing L.A.’s rough road ahead

BY KEVIN RECTOR

Craig Fugate, who led the Federal Emergency Management Agency in the Obama administration, has seen a lot of natural disasters. He knows the difference between destruction and utter devastation, and puts the nation’s truly cataclysmic events — those that erase entire communities in a blink — in a category all their own.

The wildfires that have ravaged Los Angeles in recent days fit into that group, he said.

“This is your Hurricane Katrina,” Fugate said in an

interview with The Times. “It will forever change the community. It will be a touch point that everybody will remember, before and after. And for Los Angeles, this will become one of the defining moments of the community, the city and the county’s history.”

Many in L.A. and across California already understand the before: Bone-dry months with no rain. Deadly Santa Ana winds at hurricane strength. Built-out suburbs in one of the most densely populated regions in the nation, bumping up against kindling-dry forest and scrubland.

[See Aid, A8]



POWER lines over Eaton Canyon on Sunday. Some people have questioned whether all of the devastated areas should be rebuilt, given the ongoing threats. BRIAN VAN DER BRUG Los Angeles Times

TOWER STUDIED AS FIRE ORIGIN

BY NOAH GOLDBERG AND SALVADOR HERNANDEZ

As officials try to determine the cause of a wildfire that has burned an estimated 7,000 structures in and around Altadena, investigators keep returning to one place: an electrical transmission tower in Eaton Canyon.

The once-lush hillside has been charred by flames spread by intense winds from the open space into the heart of suburban communities.

Investigators were coming and going up the mountain, an area off-limits to media, utilities and fire departments.

“Nobody is allowed up there besides investigators,” said Wayne Howerton, an investigator for the California Department of Fire and Forestry Protection. “It’s currently an investigation into the start of the Eaton fire.”

Early photos and videos taken by residents captured what appeared to be the first flames of the deadly fire, burning at the base of a Southern California Edison electrical transmission tower before racing down

[See Eaton, A9]

Newsom eases state laws to aid rebuilding

BY SEEMA MEHTA, LIAM DILLON AND ROSANNA XIA

Landmark California environmental laws will be suspended for wildfire victims seeking to rebuild their homes and businesses, according to an executive order signed Sunday by Gov. Gavin Newsom.

Requirements for building permits and reviews in the California Environmental Quality Act and the California Coastal Act — often considered onerous by developers — will be eased for victims of the fires in Pacific Palisades, Altadena and other communities, according to the order.

“California leads the nation in environmental stewardship. I’m not going to give that up,” Newsom told journalist Jacob Soboroff on NBC’s “Meet the Press.” “But one thing I won’t give into is delay. Delay is denial for people: lives, traditions, places torn apart, torn asunder.”

Dan Dunmoyer, presi-

[See Rebuild, A12]



CHRIS PIZZELLO Associated Press

CHIMNEYS are all that remain at Andrew McNally House, built in 1887 by a co-founder of Rand McNally.

Numerous landmarks gone in ‘mass erasure of heritage’

BY DANIEL MILLER

Will Rogers’ ranch home. Pasadena Waldorf School. Robert Bridges House. The Bunny Museum. Andrew McNally House. Theatre Palisades. The Zane Grey Estate.

The Palisades and Eaton infernos have laid waste to more than 30 structures considered historic in what preservationists believe is the single worst loss of such properties in the region’s history.

“It’s staggering and heartbreaking — I don’t know any other way to put it,” said Ken Bernstein, prin-

icipal city planner at Los Angeles City Planning’s Office of Historic Resources. “This is widespread destruction of significant architecture and places that are cherished in our communities.”

The tally could grow, perhaps dramatically, as an accounting of the losses continues. Though institutions including the Getty Villa were saved, the fates of many other notables — such as several influential mid-century Case Study Houses built with Arts & Architecture magazine’s sponsorship — remain unknown.

The Los Angeles Conservancy said Friday afternoon

[See Landmarks, A9]

First, they lost home coverage, then homes

BY LAURENCE DARMIENTO AND SUMMER LIN

Last year, Francis Bischetti said he learned that the annual cost of the homeowners policy he buys from Farmers Insurance for his Pacific Palisades home was going to soar from \$4,500 to \$18,000 — an amount he could not possibly afford.

Neither could he get onto the California FAIR Plan, which provides fewer benefits, because he said he would have to cut down 10 trees around his roof line to lower the fire risk — something else the 55-year-old personal assistant found too costly to manage.

So he decided he would do what’s called “going bare” — not buying any coverage on his home in the community’s El Medio neighborhood. He figured if he watered his property year round, that might be protection enough given its location south of Sunset Boulevard.

It wasn’t. The home he lived in for nearly all his life burned down Tuesday along with more than 10,000 other homes and structures damaged or destroyed in the worst fire event in the history of Los Angeles. Sixteen deaths have been confirmed countywide.

“It was surrealistic,” he said. “I’ve grown up and lived here off and on for 50

[See Insurance, A6]

Cabinet picks to begin hearings

Senators will question Trump’s nominees for Justice, Defense and other posts. **NATION, A5**

Weather
Hazy and breezy.
L.A. Basin: 69/42. **B6**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.

What’s in store for Hollywood

A look at what’s likely to come in streaming, box office, AI and the political media. **BUSINESS, A10**

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Incoming winds pose a serious risk

There’s “potential for ... explosive fire growth” this week, meteorologist says. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

‘Are you OK?’ Thanks for asking

All the messages may feel overwhelming, but Lorraine Ali writes that she’s grateful. **A6**

Communication breakdown

After Mary McNamara evacuated, she expected better from civic leaders. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**